How to apply windows 11 taskbar layout without restarting Explorer?

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I'm trying to make a program to switch my taskbar to match my virtual desktop in Windows 11. For instance, I'd have a Desktop named "3d Modeling" where I'd have Blender, Meshmixer, etc., pinned to the taskbar, but when I switch to the "3d Printing" Desktop then the taskbar would have SuperSlicer, Lychee, etc., pinned instead.

I have most of this working using an XML layout file, and using some powershell and the VirtualDesktop module to import the layout that matches the current desktop. The layout will be imported, but the taskbar won't reflect that change unless explorer.exe is restarted. But, when I restart Explorer, the program starts throwing a bunch of errors, I'm assuming because the module is unable to reconnect to the new Explorer process. The program works as expected other than the taskbar layouts not visually displaying (desktop switch is detected, new layout is selected properly, and layout is imported successfully) if Explorer is not restarted.

I would much rather not have to fully restart Explorer since that causes a bunch of stuff to disappear from the screen. I have gone down the rabbit hole a bit trying to get this to work using some C#, specifically following this thread and poking through the code for the AdaptiveTaskbar module. Both of those are older than Win11, so I'm thinking something may have changed since then. So far I haven't managed to get it to refresh the taskbar at all, and I'm not experienced enough with the Windows API to know where to look next.

So my question is: is there a way to do this in Win11? It doesn't necessarily have to be a C# or Powershell solution. Here's my most recent code, the relevant parts taken from AdaptiveTaskbar in case there's maybe a small thing I'm missing. I have also tried it using `SendMessageTimeout`.

```
Import-Module VirtualDesktop


Add-Type -Namespace Win32 -Name NativeMethods -MemberDefinition @"
    [DllImport("User32.dll", SetLastError=true, CharSet=CharSet.Auto)]
    public static extern bool SendNotifyMessage(IntPtr hWnd, uint Msg, IntPtr
wParam, string lParam);
"@


$lastDesktopIndex = -1
$currentDesktopIndex = 0
$currentDesktopName = ''

while ($True) {

    $currentDesktopIndex = Get-DesktopIndex -Desktop $(Get-CurrentDesktop)
    $currentDesktopName = Get-DesktopName -Desktop $(Get-CurrentDesktop)
```

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```
"$PSScriptRoot\taskbars\$currentDesktopName.xml" -MountPath "C:\"
        Write-Output "$currentDesktopIndex : $currentDesktopName :
$PSScriptRoot\taskbars\$currentDesktopName.xml"
        # Stop-Process -name explorer
        # Start-Process -FilePath "explorer.exe"
        [void] ([Win32.Nativemethods]::SendNotifymessage([IntPtr]0xffff, 0x1a,
[IntPtr]::Zero, "TraySettings"))
    }

    $lastDesktopIndex = $currentDesktopIndex

    #Start-Sleep -Seconds 1
    Read-Host -Prompt "Press any key to continue"

}
```

c# powershell winapi taskbar windows-11

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asked May 10 at 20:52



The Beanstalk
770 5 19

1 Note that "restarting explorer" can be done in a (quite) smooth way using the official Restart Manager API: learn.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/win32/rstmgr/.... It will (try to) preserve current open windows, settings, etc and not kill the explorer task(s) abruptly. – Simon Mourier May 11 at 5:59

I did see that floating around, but I think I'd still rather not have to restart explorer at all if it's possible, and it seems that it at least used to be possible. Still, definitely worth trying, I'll give it a go a little later today. – The Beanstalk May 11 at 15:50

No dice on using Restart Manager either, same issue with the module as reported above. It might close more gracefully, but the taskbar and icons still disappear so I'd like to try to accomplish this with a message if possible. – The Beanstalk May 11 at 23:32

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